

Comments for Planning Application DM2025/01591

Application Summary

Application Number: DM2025/01591

Address: Ambulance Station Dorset Road Belmont SM2 6JH

Proposal: Change of use from Sui Generis (Ambulance Station) to mixed use Classes F1 (Places of Worship) and F2 (Community Hub) involving the erection of a part one, part two storey front and side extension, increase in height to part of building and provision of cycle and refuse stores.

Case Officer: Polly Davidson

Customer Details

Name: Mr Syed Imran Abbasi

Address: 219 Banstead Road Banstead SM7 1RB

Comment Details

Commenter Type:

Stance: Customer made comments in support of the Planning Application

Comment Reasons:

Comment: I am delighted to write in support of the planning application for change of use of the former Ambulance Station at Dorset Road, Blemont, to a mixed use Place of Worship and Community Hub facility.

I live in Banstead and can conveniently access the proposed Place of Worship and Community Hub facility at Dorset Road on foot, by bicycle or by car.

I moved to my current Banstead home from Wallington in late 2024 and one of the first things that I investigated was if there was provision for congregational Friday prayers in the area. It was then that I learnt about BASMA and the Friday prayers that they arrange at the community hall in St John's Church, Northdown Road, Belmont.

For the last one year, I have been attending BASMA organized Friday prayers at St John's Church. Every Friday, a team of volunteers has to arrive early at St John's Church to tidy the community hall, spread prayer mats and set up acoustics. After the Friday prayers, everything has to be cleared away again. The community pools funds to rent the space on an ongoing basis. I feel that the existing arrangement is at best a temporary solution to the needs of the community, which requires a permanent prayer hall and ancillary facilities in the area.

I was therefore enthused when BASMA shared the opportunity to purchase the former Ambulance Station at Dorset Road, as a possible future home for a Prayer Hall and a Community Hub. I agreed with the vision that as a non-domestic use site, the former Ambulance Centre could be repurposed to continue serving the needs of the residents as a Community Hub, with provision for

a prayer hall for Muslim worship. BASMA launched a fundraising appeal for purchase of the former Ambulance Station and I joined the wider community in contributing funds for this project.

I support the planning application as my family and I would personally benefit from having a Prayer Hall and Community Hub at Dorset Road. As a family we will use the prayer hall for Friday congregational prayers. I typically work from home on Fridays and it is important for me to be able to complete Friday prayers during my one-hour lunch break. The proximity of the proposed prayer hall at Dorset Road will enable me to do so. My father, who is 82 years of age, will benefit from joining programs that are proposed to be organised for seniors. My wife and children will benefit from the many health, wellbeing, educational and social initiatives that are planned to be hosted at the proposed community hub.

I am also supportive of the application as it is thoughtfully conceived, modest in scale, and is sensitive to the residential character of the immediate surroundings. I note that the proposed development has 14 parking spaces, which is double the parking provision at St John's church, where Friday prayers are currently held. The planned facility will also have secure cycle racks, which will encourage travelling to and from the Community Hub by cycle. As an avid cyclist, I anticipate cycling to the proposed facility and making use of the secure cycle racks. Thus, the proposed facility is likely to reduce parking demand on Northdown Road, Queens Road and Avenue Road, especially during Friday prayer times.

To allay any concerns about higher traffic, improper parking or higher noise in the vicinity, I would like to highlight that just as regular prayers are enjoined upon Muslims, kindness and consideration to neighbours is also obligatory on us. In verse 4:36 Quran instructs Muslims to "Worship God alone and associate none with Him. And be kind to parents, relatives, orphans, the poor, near and distant neighbours, friends, travellers and those who are in your charge. Indeed Allah does not love the arrogant and boastful." At nearly every Friday prayers at St John's Church, the congregation is instructed to park considerately, show respect and kindness to neighbours, and keep noise at a minimum while travelling to and from prayers. The same ethos will extend to the proposed Community Hub and Prayer Hall at Dorset Road.

I would like to conclude by reiterating my support for this proposal as it demonstrates sensitivity to the immediate surroundings and will promote positive outcomes in terms of social cohesion and community wellbeing. I would, therefore, urge the Planning Committee to approve the application DM2025/01591.

Thank you!